SPIRITUAL/RELIGIOUS FALSE BELIEF #98 · MARRIAGE, SEX & FAMILY

“Sex is dirty, even in marriage.”

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Where it often comes from

Growing up where sex was never discussed, or only talked about as shameful. Strict warnings before marriage that did not change after the wedding. Past sexual sin, abuse, or trauma. Messages that the body is sinful. Feeling guilty about desire, even with your spouse.

What Scripture teaches

God created sex as a good gift within marriage. From the beginning, husband and wife became one flesh and were naked and not ashamed. Scripture says the marriage bed should be honored and kept undefiled. The Song of Solomon celebrates the delight of married love. Paul teaches that husbands and wives should not deprive each other. Sex within marriage is not dirty; it is honored by God.

> *“Marriage should be honored by all and the marriage bed kept undefiled, for God will judge the sexually immoral and adulterers”* **(Hebrews 13:4)**.

Also see

> “For this reason a man will leave his father and mother and be united to his wife, and they will become one flesh. And the man and his wife were both naked, and they were not ashamed” **(Genesis 2:24–25)**.

> “You are altogether beautiful, my darling; in you there is no flaw” **(Song of Solomon 4:7)**.

> “The husband should fulfill his marital duty to his wife, and likewise the wife to her husband. The wife does not have authority over her own body, but the husband. Likewise the husband does not have authority over his own body, but the wife. Do not deprive each other, except by mutual consent and for a time, so you may devote yourselves to prayer. Then come together again, so that Satan will not tempt you through your lack of self-control” **(1 Corinthians 7:3–5)**.

> “For every creation of God is good, and nothing that is received with thanksgiving should be rejected, because it is sanctified by the word of God and prayer” **(1 Timothy 4:4–5)**.

Common self-statements

- Sex is something to be ashamed of.
- Good Christians shouldn’t enjoy sex.
- I feel guilty after intimacy with my spouse.
- Desire is sinful, even in marriage.
- God looks away from that part of our lives.
- My body is dirty.

Common logical errors

- **Overgeneralization:** Carrying warnings about sex outside marriage into marriage.
- **Emotional reasoning:** Concluding “I feel ashamed, so it must be wrong.”
- **Mental filter:** Overlooking what Scripture says about sex as a gift.

- **Labeling:** Calling God's good gift "dirty."

Challenging questions

- What did God say about the first husband and wife in Genesis 2:25?
- What does Hebrews 13:4 say about the marriage bed?
- Does Scripture celebrate marital love?
- Where did I learn that sex is dirty?
- Could past hurt or abuse be affecting my feelings?
- Can I receive this gift with thanksgiving?
- Who could help me talk about this safely?

Truth summary

> Sex within marriage is not dirty. God created it as a good gift. The marriage bed is honored by God, and husband and wife can enjoy each other without shame. Past messages or hurts may affect my feelings, but God's Word says this gift is good, and I can receive it with thanksgiving.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Sex, Normal
- Marriage
- Guilt/Shame
- Marriage Guidance
- Thankful

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Marriage
- Sexual Sin

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> **Overcoming Anxiety** · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Sex is dirty, even in marriage"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Sex is dirty, even in marriage." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What did God say about the first couple?
- ☐ What does Hebrews 13:4 say?
- ☐ Does Scripture celebrate marital love?
- ☐ Where did I learn sex is dirty?
- ☐ Could past hurt be affecting me?
- ☐ Can I receive this gift with thanks?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God created sex as a good gift within marriage.
- ☐ The marriage bed is honored by God.
- ☐ Husband and wife can be together without shame.
- ☐ I can receive this gift with thanksgiving.
- ☐ Past messages do not define God's truth.
- ☐ Everything God created is good.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **Hebrews 13:4**
  "Marriage should be honored by all and the marriage bed kept undefiled, for God will judge the sexually immoral and adulterers."
- [ ] **Genesis 2:24–25**
  "For this reason a man will leave his father and mother and be united to his wife, and they will become one flesh. And the man and his wife were both naked, and they were not ashamed."
- [ ] **Song of Solomon 4:7**
  "You are altogether beautiful, my darling; in you there is no flaw."
- [ ] **1 Corinthians 7:3–5**
  "The husband should fulfill his marital duty to his wife, and likewise the wife to her husband. The wife does not have authority over her own body, but the husband. Likewise the husband does not have authority over his own body, but the wife. Do not deprive each other, except by mutual consent and for a time, so you may devote yourselves to prayer. Then come together again, so that Satan will not tempt you through your lack of self-control."
- [ ] **1 Timothy 4:4–5**
  "For every creation of God is good, and nothing that is received with thanksgiving should be rejected, because it is sanctified by the word of God and prayer."

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Thanksgiving log:** Each day, write one thing I appreciate about my spouse and thank God for the gift of marriage.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, 1 Timothy 4:4 becomes: "For every creation of God is good, and nothing that **Sarah** receives with thanksgiving should be rejected."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Sex, Normal" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Read Genesis 2:18–25,** and write what it says about God's design for married love.
- ☐ **Talk honestly with your spouse** about messages you learned growing up.
- ☐ **Meet with a Christian counselor** if past abuse or trauma affects intimacy.
- ☐ **Thank God aloud** for the gift of your marriage.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Sex is dirty, even in marriage": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One thing I appreciate about my spouse
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Sex is dirty, even in marriage.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, thank You for creating marriage and the gift of intimacy. Help me reject the lie that sex is dirty, even in marriage. Heal any shame I carry from the past, and help me receive Your good gift with thanksgiving and joy. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.